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SECURITY



Flights grounded as  
Russia's largest airline  
Aeroflot hacked and  
systems 'destroyed'



Zack Whittaker — 6:33 AM PDT · July 28, 2025

Flights across Russia have been grounded after a cyberattack hit the country's largest airline, Aeroflot, on Monday.

Details of the cyberattack remain limited, but a pro-Ukrainian hacker group [known](#) for targeting Russian organizations called Client Crow took credit for the cyberattack [alongside Belarusian hackers](#), citing Russia's ongoing war in Ukraine.

The group said [in a Telegram post](#), seen by TechCrunch, that it had taken control of Aeroflot's critical systems, including terabytes of internal company data. The group said it "destroyed" the airline's systems that it had access to. Screenshots posted by the hackers allegedly show access to several Aeroflot systems, including its internal active directory of internal users and several file shares.

The hackers also claimed to have the personal data of all Russians who have "ever flown with Aeroflot."

Aeroflot's website was currently unavailable on Monday, with an error message saying it had been "temporarily restricted."

Footage from inside Moscow's Sheremetyevo Airport (pictured) shows a departure screen showing dozens of canceled flights.

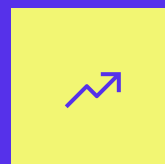
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A [statement from Russian prosecutors](#) confirmed more than 60 flights were canceled, citing a “hacker attack.” Prosecutors said they had launched a criminal investigation into the cyberattack.

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**Zack Whittaker**

Security Editor |

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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Activision investigating password-stealing malware targeting game players



Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 1:38 PM PDT · March 28, 2024

Video game giant Activision is investigating a hacking campaign that's targeting players with the goal of stealing their credentials, TechCrunch has learned.

At this point, the hackers' specific goals — apart from stealing passwords for various types of accounts — are unclear. Somehow, the hackers are getting malware on the victims' computers and then stealing passwords for their gaming accounts and crypto wallets, among others, according to sources.

A person with knowledge of the incidents, who asked to remain anonymous because they weren't authorized to speak to the press, said that people at Activision Blizzard are investigating, trying to “help remove the malware,” and “working on identifying and remediating player accounts for anyone affected.”

“There is not enough data yet on how [the malware] is spreading,” the person said. “It could be only affecting folks who have third-party tools installed.”

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Do you know more about this hack? Or other video game hacking incidents? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely

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Activision spokesperson Delaney Simmons told TechCrunch that the company is aware of “claims that some player credentials across the broader industry could be compromised from malware from downloading or using unauthorized software,” and

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Zebleer described the effort as an “infostealer malware campaign,” where malware designed as legitimate-looking software unknowingly installed by the victim surreptitiously steals their usernames and passwords.

Zebleer told TechCrunch that he found out about the hacking campaign when a PhantomOverlay customer had their account for the cheat software stolen. At that point, Zebleer added, he started investigating and was able to find the database of stolen credentials that the hackers were amassing.

After that, Zebleer said he contacted Activision Blizzard as well as other cheat makers, whose users appear to be affected.

TechCrunch obtained a sample of the allegedly stolen logins, and verified that a portion of the data are genuine credentials. It’s not clear how old or recent the data is.

At this point, there are no reasons to believe regular players of Activision games are at risk, just those who use third-party apps such as cheats.

In any case, as Activision's Simmons told TechCrunch, users who suspect they may have been compromised can change their password and activate two-factor authentication.

*Added additional details from Activision in the sixth paragraph.*

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

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Russian government  
spies targeted Ukraine



# using tools developed by cybercriminals

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

9:00 AM PST · December 11, 2024

A Russian-government-backed hacking group targeted Ukraine's military using tools and infrastructure developed by cybercriminals, according to new research.

On Wednesday, [Microsoft published a report](#) detailing a hacking campaign carried out by a group it calls Secret Blizzard, which the U.S. Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) [previously said](#) "is a known unit within Center 16" of the Russian Federal Security Service (FSB), and which other security companies refer to as [Turla](#).

Microsoft researchers wrote in the report, shared with TechCrunch ahead of publication, that Secret Blizzard used a botnet known as Amadey, which [is allegedly sold](#) on Russian hacking forums and developed by a cybercriminal group, to attempt to break into "devices associated with the Ukrainian military" between March and April of this year. While admitting that it's still investigating how Secret Blizzard gained access to Amadey, the company thinks the hacking group either used the botnet by paying for it as malware as a service or hacked into it.

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“Secret Blizzard has been using footholds from third parties — either by surreptitiously stealing or purchasing access — as a specific and deliberate method to establish footholds of espionage value,” according to the report, referring to the Amadey botnet as one of those third parties.

One of the hackers’ goals was to evade detection. Sherrod DeGrippe, Microsoft’s director of threat intelligence strategy, told TechCrunch that “using commodity tools allows the threat actor to potentially hide their origin and make attribution more difficult.”

## Contact Us

Do you have more information about Russian hackers targeting Ukraine? Or other cyberespionage operations? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase [@lorenzofb](#), or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

The Amadey botnet is normally used by cybercriminals to install a cryptominer, according to the report. Microsoft is confident that the hackers behind Amadey and those behind Secret Blizzard are different, DeGrippe said.

In this campaign, Secret Blizzard targeted computers related to the Ukrainian Army and Ukrainian Border Guard, DeGrippe told TechCrunch. Microsoft said these recent cyberattacks are “at least the second time since 2022 that Secret Blizzard has used a cybercrime campaign to facilitate a foothold for its own malware in Ukraine.”

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Secret Blizzard is known to target “ministries of foreign affairs, embassies, government offices, defense departments, and defense-related companies worldwide” with a focus on long-term espionage and intelligence collection, according to Microsoft’s report.

In this case, the Secret Blizzard malware sample that Microsoft analyzed was designed to gather information about a victim’s system — such as device name and what, if any, antivirus software is

installed — as a first step to then deploy other malware and tools.

According to Microsoft’s researchers, Secret Blizzard deployed this malware on devices to determine whether the targets were “of further interest.” For example, Secret Blizzard targeted devices using [Starlink](#), SpaceX’s satellite service, [which has been used by the Ukrainian military](#) in their operations fighting invading Russian forces.

DeGrippo said that the company is confident that this hacking campaign was conducted by Secret Blizzard in part because the hackers used custom backdoors called Tavdig and KazuarV2, “never seen used by other groups.”

Last week, [Microsoft](#) and security firm [Black Lotus Lab](#) published reports that showed how Secret Blizzard has co-opted the tools and infrastructure of another nation-state hacking group for its espionage activities since 2022. In that case, according to the two companies’ research, Secret Blizzard piggybacked on a Pakistan-based hacking group to military and intelligence targets in Afghanistan and India. At the time, Microsoft noted that Secret Blizzard has used this technique of taking advantage of other hackers’ tools and infrastructure since 2017, in cases involving Iranian government hackers and a Kazakhstan hacking group, among others.

The Russian embassy in Washington, D.C., and the FSB did not respond to requests for comment.

***Correction:** This story was updated in December 11 to correct a link to a CISA report.*

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